

Eight Thousand Years of Solitude

A Brahmin widow symbolises a community's decline in a sprawling first novel set in curd-rice country



THE TOSS OF A LEMON
by PADMA VISWANATHAN
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■ **By Geeta Doctor**

It's hard not to sound like a blurb writer but for a debut novel, Padma Viswanathan has pulled an astonishing feat. It's a brilliant *tour de force*. Even though it's a saga set in curd-rice country, Viswanathan begins her story in the environs of a small village in Tamil Nadu, near Thiruchi (Thiruchirappalli) and documents the decline of the Brahmin community that has dominated the place through centuries—eight thousand years as one of them puts it—through a tiny wizened Brahmin widow. A less un-prepossessing figure could not have been imagined. Brahmin widows of that era (from the turn of the 19th to early 20th century) were consigned to be invisible. They are forced to look at the world through the crack in the wooden doors of their kitchens. Their lives are an endless round of feeding and fending for the family. They eat last and are the first to wake up in the morning for a dip in the river unseen by others. The prohibitions are such that even caressing their own children could be seen as polluting. The rigidity of the rules imposed on widows by their own families only reflects the larger rules of caste barriers and discrimination that inform the rest of the society.

They most often begin as child brides. Sivagami is 10 when she marries Hanumarathnam who can cast horoscopes. He predicts his own early death and as surely as the stars career across the sky, fulfils his fate. Those few years of their life together as husband and wife, with two small children, give Sivagami a degree of independent thinking that powers her actions from that moment onward.

Viswanathan's first image of her is to comment on the way she carries herself. "Her shoulders are narrow but appear solid, as though the blades were fused to protect her heart from her back. She carries herself with an attractive stiffness: her shoulder straight and always aligned."

It's a quality that allows us to view Sivagami as a dancer who performs her role through a tumultuous life with a grace that comes from an inner fire. Even as it forces us to ask at what cost this unbreakable stance is maintained.

SAURABH SINGH



Sivagami's character and travails represent that of the Brahmin community that in her lifetime (1896-1962) had to adapt itself to change. Her own son Vairum, who plays the devil's advocate of the need to accept the new ways, is her equal in his adamant efforts to destroy the old systems. In between the two, there are all the other characters—her children, grandchildren and later great-grandchildren. It's an epic saga in every sense of the word.

How does Viswanathan pull it off? It's hard to explain. It's not just nostalgia, though there is some of that when recreating the fictional past of a family that might be her own. She

creates a tableau that encompasses the histories of many such families. One hears in it, for instance, fragments from the early poems of a poet like R. Parthasarathy recording the moment of his grandmother's death and the relatives scrambling under her bed for a nose-ring stud. It's not just the itch for self-discovery that afflicts so many diaspora writers. The writer herself hardly appears in the text. She is subsumed in telling of her tale that is as complex and fascinating as the decline of the once-proud Brahmin community in rural Tamil Nadu.

As such the Brahmins took themselves and their roles in the society with a pride that with the passing of such archetypes, the code of the Samurai, for instance, as seen through the eyes of a Kurosawa or Mishima, does not appear barbaric as it frequently was but as worthy of our

respect, if not admiration. She also attempts to locate the fictional history within the real-life political and social concerns of the time. Since, obviously she's had to rely on secondary sources, they do intrude sometimes, as personalities like Kalki and Rukmini Arundale have walk-on parts, to allow issues such as the Devadasi movement or the re-marriage of widows to be debated. For the most part, however, she keeps a tight grip on her material. Like the motes of gold that one of the characters leaves around her as she walks through the dark, Viswanathan allows us a small sigh for the glory that could not last. ■